

Building Alternative Homes

By: Chaz Wilke - Staff Writer



The familiar sounds associated with home construction may soon be nothing more than a memory. Modern home building techniques and materials are becoming increasingly varied. So enjoy the sound of nails being hammered and buzz saws slicing through fresh wood while you can, because new alternative materials may soon reduce building costs as well as the average American home's carbon footprint.

Drastic transformations in building materials and total average square footage are starting to reshape what we might one day consider home. From Styrofoam building materials to dumpster dwellings, homes of the future are poised to be more diverse than ever.

Styrofoam Homes

On face value, building any permanent structure out of Styrofoam might seem like a foolish decision. One would think that anyone could scrape a hole into your home. However, Leigh Overland Architect uses a build system called Insulated Concrete Form (ICF). This process uses Styrofoam as a building block (<http://huff.to/1xliWID>), think LEGO, to build structures. Concrete and steel fill the forms to strengthen the building.

(<https://solarmehome.com/?cid=28806>)

(<https://pursuemortgage.com/?cid=28806>)

ICF Construction | Can Every Man Have His Castle? | CT



"The time has come to build with a product that's not gonna only last for decades but will last for centuries," says Leigh Overland.



Dumpsters

Jeff Wilson, an environmental studies professor and dean at Huston-Tillotson University in Austin, Texas, is in the process of transforming a dumpster into a habitable structure. Following a divorce, Wilson decided to take an extreme approach to bachelor downsizing. He moved from a 2,500 square foot home into a cozy 36 square foot dumpster (<http://bit.ly/1tigbUb>).

FreeScore360
with your 7-day Trial
& a monthly rebill of \$29.95

**Click Here
to get started!**

(<https://secure.rspcdn.com/xpr/r/PID/3569/SID>)

Your Home Windows

Replace
Or
Repair

Affordable Price

GET FREE
ESTIMATE

www.ewindowquotes.com

(9nl.it/replaceorrepair)

Rental KHARMA

**BUILD YOUR
CREDIT WITH
YOUR RENT
PAYMENTS**

**GET
STARTED
NOW**

- ✓ Easy Registration
- ✓ Get Credit for Past Rent
- ✓ Money Back Guarantee
- ✓ 3 minute sign up

(<https://secure.rspcdn.com/xpr/r/PID/3960/SID>)
AffiliateReferenceID=hl101)

Related Articles

The Dumpster Project



Known around campus as Professor Dumpster, Wilson is interested in starting a national conversation with his experiment in dumpster living. "It's obviously kind of a shocking idea and, initially, people think it's a little bit crazy, but it gets the conversation started within and between groups and within and between ages," he said in a [recent interview](http://bit.ly/1xlpKO) (<http://bit.ly/1xlpKO>).

Wilson split his project into three distinct phases. Only recently beginning Phase 2, Wilson invites people to follow his progress at [dumpsterproject.org](http://bit.ly/1tigbUb) (<http://bit.ly/1tigbUb>).

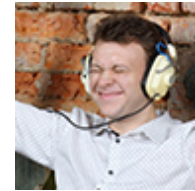


Glass Bottles



(<http://homeliving101.com/lifestyle/get-off-my-lawn-epic-neighbor-feuds-and-how-to-avoid-them/>)

We all dream of finding the perfect home. We obsess over the number of bedrooms, being close to good schools, and



(<http://homeliving101.com/hl-trends/absolutely-obsolete/>)

Few things are permanent in this disposable culture of ours. But it's still hard to believe how quickly to-



(<http://homeliving101.com/lifestyle/trimming-the-fringe-of-suburbia/>)

There is no more potent image of American prosperity than a sprawling tree-lined street filled with large single-family homes. In a word: suburbia - born...

There are many [glass-bottle houses \(http://bit.ly/10ZHQDF\)](http://bit.ly/10ZHQDF) around the country, but we'll focus on Bottle Village. Similar to Salvation Mountain in Niland, Calif., Bottle Village in Simi Valley, Calif., was the work of a single person. Tressa Prisbrey "transformed her one-third acre rural lot into Bottle Village, a fantasyland of shrines, wishing wells, walkways, fountains, follies, plus 15 structures to house her collections – all made from found objects," says the Bottle Village [official website \(http://bit.ly/1GuGLE7\)](http://bit.ly/1GuGLE7).

Starting her work in 1956 at age 60, Prisbrey worked until 1981 creating her immersive walking tour. Entry to Bottle Village was only a quarter, which in today's money would be less than \$2. Travelers from all ends of the Earth could enjoy some time in the tranquil, multicolored glass-mosaic structures.

Prisbrey found most of her bottles in a local dump. Working on something so beautiful with a meager budget only pushed Prisbrey to create something that much more impressive. "Anyone can do anything with a million dollars. Look at Disney. But it takes more than money to make something out of nothing, and look at the fun I have doing it," she said.

Tires and Trash

The New-Mexico-based architecture firm Earthship Biotecture develops sustainable structures made primarily of dirt, tires and aluminum cans, and has been at it for over 40 years. Promising a build time from "[dirt to door knobs \(http://bit.ly/1qsf6JM\)](http://bit.ly/1qsf6JM) in five weeks" for the company's "radically sustainable buildings."

In 2009, documentary filmmaker Oliver Hodge created the award winning film Garbage Warrior, highlighting Earthship's founder Michael Reynolds' mission to create sustainable structures. That documentary is provided below. [WARNING: Contains some explicit language]

Garbage Warrior Full Length Documentary



“Thanks to solar power, water stills and internal septic tanks, these ‘[earth ships](http://thetim.es/1xIkeDp)’ (<http://thetim.es/1xIkeDp>) are ‘off-grid’ not reliant on any external electricity, gas, water and sewer systems,” says Ed Potton at The Times of London.

To the passing observer, Earthship’s designs may seem farfetched or downright unbelievable. But over 40 years, many have taken the plunge on a 100% sustainable Earthship home. And it’s not all crunchy-hippie types that call these structures home. High-end Earthships can rival a small single-family home in price. Trent Wolbe at The Verge explains, “With a construction cost around \$225 per square foot, or [\\$300,000 for a one-bedroom, one-bath home](http://bit.ly/1xIklim) (<http://bit.ly/1xIklim>), it’s certainly not for people who don’t believe wholeheartedly in the concept.”



Wood Shipping Pallets

Each year seems to bring at least one large-scale natural disaster somewhere across the globe. This means that potentially hundreds of thousands of people might find themselves in need of temporary housing at a moment's notice. You might remember the vast [tent city \(http://bit.ly/1qsfh7S\)](http://bit.ly/1qsfh7S) that provided meager emergency shelter to many Haitians after an earthquake leveled much of the small country.

An ideal structure for situations like this would need to walk the line between speed of construction and strength of the building. I-Beam, the New York architecture and design firm, tackled this issue head on for an entry in the Transitional Housing contest by reusing shipping pallets as the main building material.

Matt Embrey at Green Upgrader states, "One transitional shelter measuring 10 x 20 feet would take [80 pallets to build \(http://bit.ly/1tNfeIH\)](http://bit.ly/1tNfeIH) and cost approximately \$500." In most disaster relief cases, food and supplies are delivered on pallets, which make this a logical choice for a building material.

Stereotactic Minibuilders

A team of researchers at the Institute for Advance Architecture in Catalonia, Spain, are taking the concept of three-dimensional printing and applying it to [building habitable structures \(http://bit.ly/1E9ahv4\)](http://bit.ly/1E9ahv4).

A group of autonomous robots extrude a material layer-by-layer that then hardens into a shell. The research team hopes to create cheap habitable structures with an automated construction site. This means buildings could be erected quickly, cheaply and free of the common human-injury liability that normally accompanies build sites.

“The robots can work simultaneously while performing different tasks, and having a fixed size they can create objects of virtually any scale, as far as material properties permit,” the researchers say. This means the same robots that build a shed can also build larger structures as well.

Takeaway

Your next home may be forged from recycled tires, soda bottles, or even old wood pallets. You might hire a group of robots to extrude the shell of your home over a just few days. Needless to say, the future of home building is looking to adapt to economic and environmental trends, which is a great thing for those looking to become homeowners in the future.

Chaz Wilke is an employee of Deka Marketing Group. Deka Marketing Group receives payment from advertisers on HomeLiving101.

Home Living 101 is owned and operated by Deka Marketing Group. The information provided on Home Living 101 is provided for informational purposes only. The operator of this website assumes no responsibility or liability for any actions taken as a result of using this website, and/or for errors or omissions in content. When you link to any third party website and/or article provided via this website, you are leaving our website. We make no representations as to the information provided at third party websites and/or third party privacy practices. Please consult with your own independent legal advisor before relying or acting on any information provided on this website and/or a third party.